

Occupational Therapy (OTBNZ) Registration Checklist

A practical, tickable checklist to work through alongside your
Occupational Therapy Board of New Zealand Registration Guide
— so nothing gets missed on the way to registration.



Before you begin

Tick as you go

Tick each box on screen as you complete it. The items are grouped into stages, roughly in the order you'll tackle them — but you can work on several at once.

This checklist is a companion to the main guide, which explains the *why* behind each step. It complements, and does not replace, the official guidance of the Occupational Therapy Board of New Zealand, who make all registration decisions.

One thing to know up front

OTBNZ assesses overseas applications individually. The written desktop competence self-assessment is the part most applicants underestimate — start drafting it early (Stage 02), and the rest of the process follows far more smoothly.

01 Before you start

Get oriented and pick the right pathway before you spend money or gather documents.

- ☐ **Confirm which pathway applies to you**
Standard overseas, abridged (UK/Ireland/Canada/South Africa), or Trans-Tasman (Ahpra)
- ☐ **If abridged: confirm your programme is WFOT-accredited**
Required for the UK/Ireland/Canada abridged route
- ☐ **Confirm you're currently registered where you trained/practise**
And that you can obtain a certificate of good standing
- ☐ **Check the English-language exemption or test need**
Test only if English isn't your first language and you don't meet a recognised-country route
- ☐ **Note that fees are payable and non-refundable**
Confirm the current figures on the Board's live fees page before budgeting

02 Competence self-assessment (start this early!)

The written desktop assessment is the centrepiece of an overseas application.

- ☐ **Download the Board's Competencies for practice**
Map your experience to each competency before you submit
- ☐ **Draft specific, evidenced examples per competency**
General statements rarely satisfy the assessors
- ☐ **Line up your OT referee to confirm it**
On the standard pathway they review and confirm your self-assessment
- ☐ **Note it's completed in the applicant portal**
After your initial application — your file isn't processed until it's done

03 Qualifications

What the Board's appointed occupational therapists assess.

- ☐ **Certified occupational therapy qualification certificate**
Original or certified copy
- ☐ **Certified academic transcript**
Original or certified copy
- ☐ **Detailed course description / syllabus (standard pathway)**
Not required on the abridged pathway
- ☐ **Be ready for primary source verification**
The Board may require it, at your own cost

04 Identity & references

Confirming who you are and that you're fit and proper.

- ☐ **Two certified forms of ID (one with a photo)**
Plus certified evidence of any name change
- ☐ **Certified translations of any non-English documents**
Alongside a certified copy in the original language
- ☐ **Three referees lined up**
Over 18, known you 12+ months, not a relative, not at your address
- ☐ **At least one referee is an occupational therapist**
Worked with you 6+ months in the last 2 years

05 Criminal history

Police checks with precise rules — easy to get slightly wrong.

- ☐ **Criminal-conviction check for your country of registration**
Plus any country lived in 6+ months in the last 10 years
- ☐ **Let the Board arrange the NZ check**
Emailed to you during processing, unless you've never been to NZ
- ☐ **Explanatory note if you have any conviction**
A conviction isn't an automatic bar — disclose fully

06 English language (if required)

Only if English isn't your first language and you don't meet a recognised-country route.

- ☐ **Sit OET (OT version) — grade B in each component**
Listening, reading, writing, speaking
- ☐ **...or IELTS Academic — at least 7.0 in each band**
Choose whichever suits you
- ☐ **Achieve the standard within 12 months if clubbing**
You may combine results across sittings
- ☐ **Results no older than 24 months at submission**
Time the test so it stays valid

07 Cultural competence (get ahead of it)

Begin thinking about this early — it's required of every applicant.

- ☐ **Note Ngā Paerewa Te Tiriti is required**
Approved online cultural-competence course via Ko Awatea LEARN
- ☐ **Request your Ko Awatea account at the right time**
Only after the Board updates your application number to a registration number
- ☐ **Understand te Tiriti o Waitangi & Māori health context**
Reflects both partners to the Treaty

08 Submit & after

Putting it together and what follows.

- ☐ **Submit your initial application & fee via MyOTBNZ**
The applicant portal
- ☐ **Complete portal steps: self-assessment, referees, CV**
Your application isn't processed until these are in
- ☐ **Post or courier the hard-copy documents**
Several documents must be supplied physically, not just uploaded
- ☐ **Respond promptly to any Board queries**
Processing can take up to 6 weeks once everything is received
- ☐ **Registration confirmed**
Apply for your practising certificate before you can work
- ☐ **Begin the Recertification Programme**
Fortnightly supervision and Te Rito for overseas-qualified registrants

HOW ETHICARE WILL SUPPORT YOU

You don't have to navigate this alone

If anything on this checklist raises a question, that's exactly what we're here for. We support and guide you through every stage — from first enquiry to starting work. The registration decision always rests with the Occupational Therapy Board of New Zealand.

READY TO BEGIN?

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